

by bit. Every success on this countermagic roll removes one level of modifier from the initial alchemy, canceling out a die allocated by its caster. This immediately alters the effect of that alchemy, as it contracts suddenly. The alchemy need not be entirely eradicated — sometimes, pruning it back is sufficient to render it effectively useless, though the original nub of the effect will remain and can be reinforced by the original caster with further use of Wu Tan.

Rituals

Rituals extend the creation of Wu Tan effects into longer, more complex actions. This has disadvantages, chief among them the amount of time necessary to prepare for and carry out the Ritual in question. Their complexity also renders them more difficult, applying a +1 difficulty to the roll assuming the ritual takes place at an auspicious site — if it is inauspicious, this penalty rises to a +2 difficulty. Dice set aside for modifiers must be set aside for all rolls. Fortunes may be used in this process, but only once throughout (so if a Fortune is used on one roll, it cannot be used on any others). The Yugen for the alchemy need be spent only once, with a surcharge of one extra Yugen to bind the ritual together. Yugen may be contributed by any participant.

Each roll should represent a unit of time, no more than an hour and no less than 20 minutes in length. A single Hsien acts as ritemaster — for every other Hsien who participates in the rite, add one die to the ritemaster's dice pool for each roll. Only four such dice may be added in this way, for five is the most auspicious number for participants in a ritual, reflecting the elemental makeup of creation.

The chief advantage of the Ritual is that her successes are cumulative, bringing greater effects within the reach of the Hsien. However, the Ritual may only last long enough for a number of rolls equal to the ritemaster's Chi (Yin or Yang, whichever is being used). Beyond that, the alchemy grows too powerful for her to control.

Fortunes

Fortunes add Fortune dice to any roll to which they apply, as the natural balance of the elements aids the Hsien in working her magic. These Fortune dice cannot be rolled, but they can be allocated to modifiers, allowing the player to retain dice that she can then roll. Some Fortunes are controllable, others are not. Therefore, certain times or places will be more auspicious than others for whatever undertaking the Hsien has planned.

Color: If the caster wears the appropriate color, this Fortune applies, though the clothing must be apparent and not hidden in any way. If the target wears the same color, this Fortune is worth two Fortune dice. Fire is associated with red, wood with green, earth with yellow, metal with white, and water with black.

Direction: By standing in the appropriate place, the weight of the world falls behind the Hsien's efforts. With one exception, she must be standing a noteworthy distance from the target to receive the benefit of this Fortune. Fire is associated with the south, wood with the east, earth with the center (which is to

say in close proximity to the target), metal with the west, and water with the north.

Dzi Dzat: Literally meaning “folded paper,” these paper representations of people or objects were, in some places, used as sacrifices. For the Hsien, constructing a paper effigy of whatever she wishes to use her magic on makes that magic more potent.

Festivals: The caster must be participating in a festival to invoke the benefit of this Fortune. The Middle Kingdom is filled with a multitude of festivals, the largest celebrated with each full moon. Festivals are always worth three Fortune dice.

Kwannon-Jin Fortune: Each Kwannon-Jin resonates with a particular element, and thus receives the benefit of this Fortune whenever they use an I Chih associated with that element. If the target is of the same Kwannon-Jin as well, this Fortune is worth two Fortune dice.

Mu-jen: Wooden dolls carved from tung or paulownia wood, then clothed identically to the target, provide a strong link through which the Hsien's magic can flow. Each doll, however, may only be used once.

Poetry: Any formal style of poetry may be used to take advantage of this Fortune, though each I Chih must have its own poem, and a new poem must be composed each year, typically at the New Year's Festival.

Season: Certain seasons are more auspicious for certain elements, as elemental magic conducts itself in its natural path through the year. Fire is associated with summer, wood with spring, metal with autumn, and water with winter. Seasons are worth two Fortune dice.

Sense: The caster and target must simultaneously experience the same sensory information to take advantage of this Fortune. Fire is associated with sight, wood with touch, earth with smell, metal with hearing, and water with taste.

Wani Form: All Hsien resonate with the magic of the elements, and so all Hsien receive two Fortune dice for any I Chih roll made while in their wani form.

I Chih

Each school of elemental alchemy is divided into five levels, ascending in scope from the most basic of understanding to grand alterations to the fabric of the world. Each of these tiers of knowledge and ability are referred to as I Chih — “righteous judgements.” These powers began as holy writ, given to the Shinma to do the work of Heaven and respond to the prayers of mortals. Now, cut off from Heaven, these powers are seemingly theirs to do with as they please. While I Chih are described in terms of specific effects and given examples, there is no limit to the effects they are capable of creating, save progression in elemental understanding, the imagination of the Shinma employing this magic, and, of course, Storyteller approval.

I Chih are all-encompassing understandings of the 10,000 Things, and as such, the examples provided following a description of each I Chih are just that — simple examples of the manifold wonders that the Hsien can, with study and focus, call forth.